

The Psychology of Testing

Psychology of testing

A tester:

- Employs professional cynicism.

- Tries to prove that the solution does not work (they are detached from the 'ownership' and inherent protection Developers have for their code).

A Developer's job is to prove the solutions does work.

Testers see other and different defects to the author/developer.

Testers are unbiased.

Testers do not make assumptions.



Psychology of testing

Need to focus on effective communication

Constructive rather than confrontational.

Present in a non-personal way.

Empathy.

Clarification.

Testers should be pedantic and sceptical, but also impartial and constructive.

Communications with developers

Communication problems may occur, particularly if testers are seen only as messengers of unwanted news about defects

Ways to improve relationships with others:

- Collaboration, not battles

- Neutral, objective, avoiding personalities

- Understand how the other person feels and why they react as they do

- Confirm that the other person has understood what you have said and vice versa.

Goal: locate defects

A successful test is one that locates a defect

If finding defects is the testers' aim:

- positive motivation - finding defects is good

- constructive - perceived as improving quality

- testers create 'tough' tests, not easy ones

If we are effective at finding defects, and then can't find any, we can be confident the system works.

Tester mindset

A destructive activity, requiring keen skills and tenacity

But also requires excellent communication skills

Destructive to products but constructive to authors and developers

Testers may benefit from a split personality?

Pedantic, skeptical, nit-picking to software

trust developers, but doubt the product

nothing 'works', until you've tested it

Impartial, advisory, constructive to developers:

'tread lightly, as you tread on their dreams'

diplomatic, but firm: the defects were there to be found, you didn't put them there.

Independence

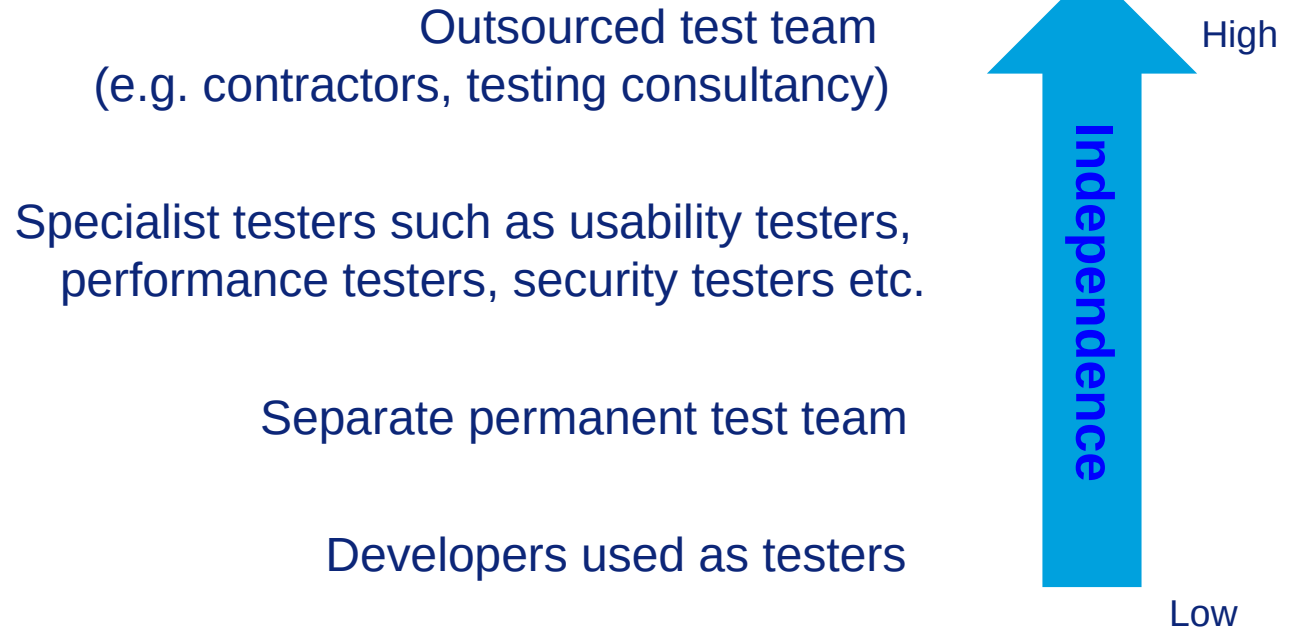
The mindset to be used while testing and reviewing is different to that used while analyzing or developing

Independent testing may be carried out at any level of testing

A certain degree of independence (avoiding the author bias) is often more effective at finding defects and failures

Independence is not, however, a replacement for familiarity, and developers can efficiently find many defects in their own code

Degrees of independence



A test for you...

Degrees of independence:

Arrange the following from the least independent to the most independent:

1. Test cases are designed by a person(s) from a different organization.
2. Test cases are designed by a person(s) from the same organisation.
3. Test cases are designed by the person(s) writing the software.
4. Test cases are designed by a person(s) from a different team.
5. Test cases are not chosen by a person.



A test for you...

Solution

3. Test cases are designed by the person(s) writing the software.
4. Test cases are designed by a person(s) from a different team.
2. Test cases are designed by another person(s) in the same organisation.
1. Test cases are designed by a person(s) from a different organization.
5. Test cases are not chosen by a person.

